AMERICA AT 250

Used To vs. Past Continuous

A conversation lesson for the 250th birthday of the USA | July 4, 2026

Name: _____ Date: _____



1 Transcripts

1.1 Reading — "The Overlooked Story of America: Four Moments That Shaped a Nation"

> **Task:**
> As you read, **underline every 'used to'** in one colour and **every 'was / were + -ing'** in another.

When people think about American history, they usually picture the famous moments: the Founding Fathers signing the Declaration, Neil Armstrong on the moon, or the Civil Rights marches. But the *overlooked* stories are just as important. And honestly? Some of them are pretty *amusing* when you look back.

Let me tell you about four moments that determined the American Dream — and how people feel about the country today.

1. The Founding Fathers Get Lucky (1776)

Here's something nobody expects: the Founding Fathers almost failed.

When they were fighting for independence, these men used to risk everything. They were writing the Declaration of Independence while, at the exact same moment, British soldiers were hunting them down. Most people have no idea how *subtle* the difference was between success and total disaster. If just a few things had gone differently, America wouldn't exist.

What's *amusing* about this? Many of the Founding Fathers were actually just regular businessmen with property back home. They weren't trying to be heroes — they wanted to make sure their businesses and land wouldn't be taxed unfairly. The American Dream of freedom? That came along for the ride.

The lasting impact? Well, it wouldn't hurt one bit to remember that revolution wasn't planned perfectly. It was messy, lucky, and full of people fighting for something they couldn't have *foreseen* would change the entire world.

Their pride in independence is still how Americans feel about the country today.

2. The Civil War: A Nation Divided (1861–1865)

Fast forward about 85 years. America used to be a country with a terrible secret: millions of people were enslaved.

While politicians were debating in Congress, enslaved people were working in fields from sunrise to sunset. The Civil War was the moment when the whole nation was fighting with itself. Brother against brother. State against state.

It's not *amusing* — it's tragic. But here's what's important: nothing could stop the momentum. When the war finally ended, slavery was abolished. The Founding Fathers had said "all men are created equal," but they hadn't lived up to it. This moment, finally, made America live up to its words.

The lasting impact changed everything. It determined what kind of country America would become.

3. The Civil Rights Movement: The Overlooked 1960s

Jump forward another hundred years. America used to tell itself a story: "We're free. We're equal." But that wasn't true.

In the 1960s, while families in New York were watching the moon landing on TV, Black Americans in the South were being arrested for sitting at lunch counters. While politicians were making speeches about the American Dream, police were using dogs and fire hoses against protesters.

Here's what's *subtle* but crucial: most white Americans didn't really understand how bad it was. They used to think "freedom" meant they didn't have to think about someone else's freedom. But Martin Luther King, Rosa Parks, and thousands of ordinary people were fighting to make sure the country would actually live up to its founding promise.

Their pride in fighting — and winning — created a lasting impact we still feel today. But it's an *overlooked* victory. How many people remember those names?

4. The Dream Goes Global (2000s–Today)

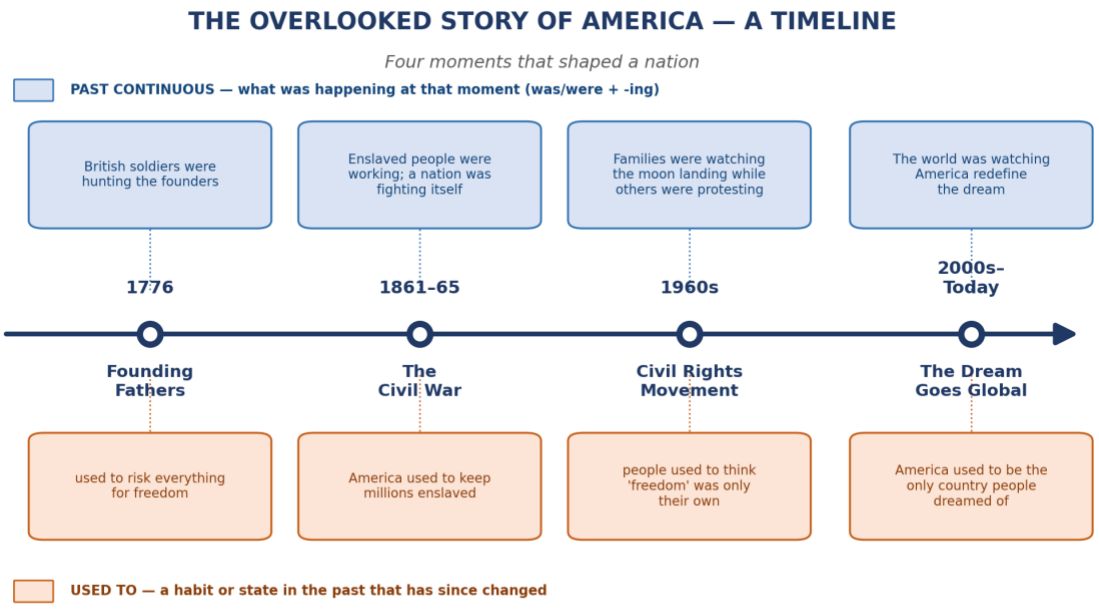
So here we are in 2026.

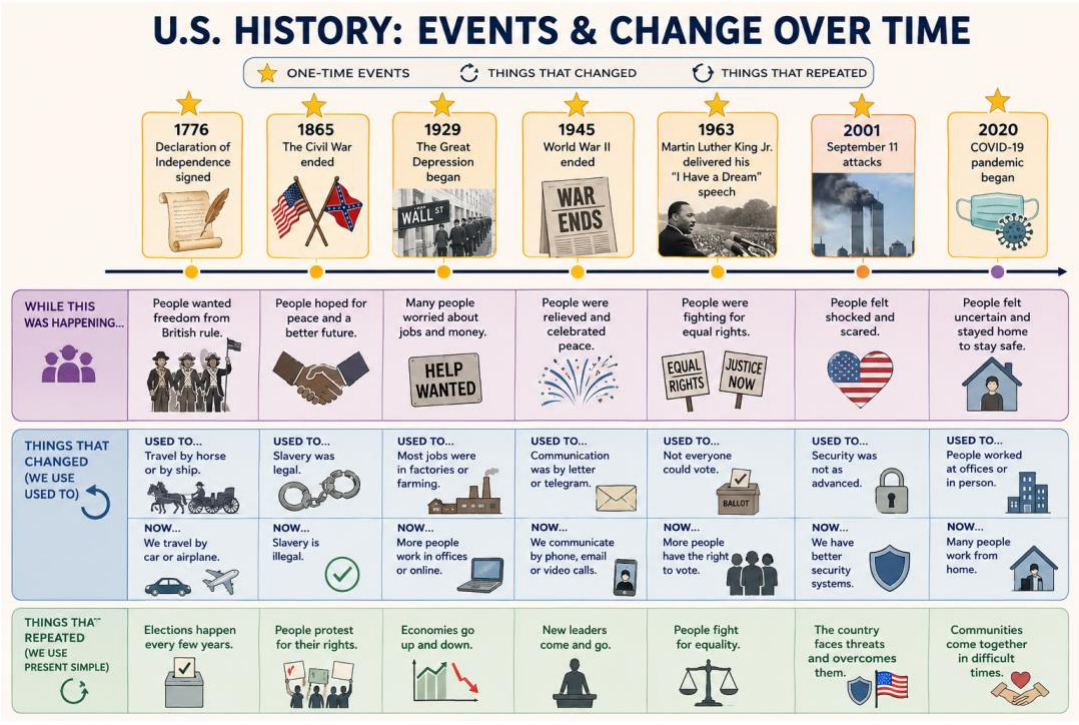
America used to be the only country people dreamed about leaving home for. The American Dream meant a house, a car, and success. Now? It's more complicated.

How do people feel about the country today? It's mixed. Some Americans are proud of how far they've come. Others see the *overlooked* problems: people without property, without healthcare, struggling to afford the dream. Some think America's founding ideals are beautiful. Others think those ideals were never meant for everyone in the first place.

What's *amusing* — and sad — is that America is still figuring out who gets to have the American Dream. After 250 years, that conversation never really ended.

But here's the thing: it wouldn't hurt one bit to remember these *overlooked* stories. Because understanding history determines how we move forward.





1.2 BBC News Report — "America at 250" (transcript)

Video: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=0v6tudV9cGE

Reporter (studio): This weekend has seen millions of Americans celebrate the 250th anniversary of the founding of their country. In Washington, there were fireworks and a spectacular military flyover, while in a speech on the National Mall, Donald Trump said the American Dream is now back. As the US reaches a momentous milestone, Sarah Smith has been finding out how Americans feel about their nation and their president.

Crowd: Happy 250 years, America!

Sarah Smith (voiceover): "Bombs bursting in the air" are described in the American national anthem. This record-breaking firework display in Washington was the largest ever — with President Trump making sure he is centre stage.

President Trump: Because America is a nation of winners. And today our country is winning again, and we're winning like never before. And God bless the United States of America.

Sarah Smith (voiceover): The night before, he'd held an anniversary event directly *overlooked* by the faces of four of America's greatest presidents at Mount Rushmore — a not-so-*subtle* hint from a man who has shared images of his own face carved into the mountain, *amusing* his fans and leaving others dismayed.

Member of the public: I think what exists today is *appropriate*. I don't feel like it should be changed.

Sarah Smith: Let's see where we could put him. Where do you think — to the left, or to the right?

Sarah Smith (voiceover): Donald Trump's poll ratings hit an all-time low, thanks to the war in Iran and the inflation it caused — but he maintains some staunch support.

Sarah Smith: So, do you think Donald Trump's face should be on Mount Rushmore?

Member of the public: It *wouldn't hurt* me one bit. I think he deserves to be up there.

Member of the public: Twenty, thirty years from now, I believe the historians will say he's been one of the greatest presidents in the history of our nation.

Sarah Smith (voiceover): The 4th of July, Independence Day, isn't about any one particular politician. It's about celebrating the founding ideals of America — and the men on the mountain all played a significant part in *determining* what the country became. Donald Trump is undoubtedly reshaping the nation today. But will his efforts have a *lasting impact*?

Historian: It remains to be seen whether he will be regarded as a transformative president or an aberration. There are plenty of examples of a person just like him who wants to come in and have power in his hands, having been shunned from it for a while — and it did not go very well.

Sarah Smith (voiceover): It's rodeo time in nearby Belle Fourche, with bareback bronco riding, mutton busting, and barrel racing — true Americana at its best. But polls suggest *pride* in America has fallen to a 25-year low, and people are concerned about what those *Founding Fathers* would make of America today.

Member of the public: Not good. We're far from the words written in the Declaration of Independence. But I think they would applaud that we're trying to hold true to their vision.

Member of the public: It doesn't seem quite as special as it used to. You've lost some freedom. Very regulated.

Sarah Smith (voiceover): The founders may not have *foreseen* today's deeply divided America — but the country has already survived far worse, and endured. Sarah Smith, BBC News, Mount Rushmore, South Dakota.

Source: BBC News, Sarah Smith reporting from Mount Rushmore, South Dakota. Lightly edited for readability. For classroom listening use.

2 Vocabulary

Key Words from the Story

Word / Phrase	Meaning	Example from the story
overlooked	not noticed; ignored or forgotten	*The overlooked stories are just as important.*
the American Dream	the belief that anyone can succeed and build a better life through hard work	*The American Dream used to mean a house, a car, and success.*
how people feel about the country	the general mood or attitude of citizens toward their nation	*After 250 years, how people feel about the country is very mixed.*
make sure	to check or take action so that something definitely happens	*They wanted to make sure their land wasn't taxed unfairly.*
subtle	not obvious; small and hard to notice	*The difference between success and disaster was very subtle.*
amusing	funny; entertaining when you look back on it	*It's amusing that the founders were ordinary businessmen.*
property	land, buildings, or possessions that someone owns	*Many founders were businessmen with property back home.*
it wouldn't hurt one bit	it would be a good idea; it would do no harm	*It wouldn't hurt one bit to remember these stories.*
determine	to decide or shape the result of something	*Understanding history determines how we move forward.*
lasting impact	a long-term effect that continues to matter	*The Civil War had a lasting impact we still feel.*
the Founding Fathers	the leaders who created the USA and wrote its founding documents	*The Founding Fathers signed the Declaration in 1776.*
pride	a feeling of satisfaction and respect for your country	*Their pride in independence still shapes America.*
foreseen	predicted; imagined in advance that something would happen	*They couldn't have foreseen how the world would change.*

Group A — History and Change

Word / Phrase	Definition	Example
★ **independence**	freedom from another country's control	*The USA declared independence from Britain in 1776.*
colonist	a person who settles in a new colony	*Early colonists built farms along the east coast.*
★ **revolution**	a sudden and complete political change	*The American Revolution changed the world forever.*
civil war	a war between groups within the same country	*The Civil War divided the USA from 1861 to 1865.*
★ **abolish**	to officially end a law or practice	*Slavery was abolished in the USA in 1865.*
era	a long period of time with a particular character	*The Jazz Age was a creative era for American music.*

Group B — Society and Culture

Word / Phrase	Definition	Example
★ **civil rights**	the rights of every person to equal treatment	*Martin Luther King fought for civil rights in the 1960s.*
segregation	separating people by race or group	*Segregation kept Black and white Americans in separate schools.*
★ **protest**	an action showing disagreement with something	*Thousands of people joined the protest in Washington.*
diversity	having many different types of people or ideas	*New York is famous for its cultural diversity.*
★ **milestone**	an important event or achievement	*The moon landing was a milestone in human history.*

Group C — Politics and Power

Word / Phrase	Definition	Example
★ **democracy**	a system where people vote to choose their leaders	*The USA was founded as a democracy.*
amendment	a change to a law or official document	*The first ten amendments are called the Bill of Rights.*

★ **constitution**	the basic laws that govern a country	*The US Constitution was written in 1787.*
bipartisan	involving both political parties	*Congress passed the bill with bipartisan support.*
★ **landmark**	an important event that marks a change	*Obama's election was a landmark moment in US history.*

3 Exercises

Exercise 1 — Vocabulary Gap-Fill

Choose the correct word or phrase from the box for each gap.

Word bank

overlooked • American Dream • how people feel about the country • make sure • subtle • amusing • property • wouldn't hurt • determining • lasting impact • Founding Fathers • pride • foreseen

1. Many important stories in history are _____ — forgotten or simply not noticed.
2. The _____ is the belief that anyone can succeed through hard work.
3. After 250 years, _____ is still very mixed — some are proud, some are worried.
4. The founders wanted to _____ their land would not be taxed unfairly.
5. The difference between success and disaster was very _____ — small and hard to see.
6. It is quite _____ that the founders were ordinary businessmen, not perfect heroes.
7. Many of the founders were businessmen who owned _____ back home.
8. It _____ one bit to remember that the revolution was messy and full of luck.
9. Understanding history matters because it helps in _____ how we move forward.
10. The Civil War had a _____ that still shapes America today.
11. The _____ signed the Declaration of Independence in 1776.
12. Americans still feel great _____ in their independence.
13. The founders could not have _____ how much the world would change.

Exercise 2 — Used To only

Read each situation. Rewrite the sentence using **used to** or **didn't use to**. The context tells you what the past was like. (+) = positive answer (–) = negative answer

1. (–)

In 1800, people walked or rode horses everywhere. Nobody had seen an airplane.

Americans _____ by plane.

2. (–)

The original US flag had 13 stars — one for each colony. Today it has 50.

The US flag _____ 50 stars.

3. (–)

In the early 1900s, Times Square was lit only by gas lamps. Electric billboards came later.

Times Square _____ electric billboards.

4. (+)

Before the 1920s, women in the USA had no right to vote. That changed in 1920.

Women _____ without the right to vote.

5. (+)

Before cars and railroads, cowboys moved cattle across the West on horseback.

Cowboys _____ cattle across the West.

6. (+)

Before smartphones, people called friends from a phone attached to the wall.

People _____ from home phones on the wall.

7. (+)

Until 1865, slavery was legal in parts of the USA. It was abolished after the Civil War.

Slavery _____ in the southern states.

8. BONUS — Trap sentence!

Americans vote for a president every 4 years. This was true in 1789 and it is still true today.

Americans _____ every 4 years. *Can you use 'used to' here? Why not?*

Exercise 3 — Past Continuous only

Complete each sentence using the **past continuous** of the verb in brackets. Each sentence has a time reference — what was happening at that exact moment?

1.

July 20, 1969. The whole world had stopped. Every television was on.

Neil Armstrong _____ (walk) on the moon for the first time in human history.

2.

April 4, 1968. King had stepped outside his hotel room for a moment.

When he was shot, Martin Luther King _____ (stand) on the balcony of the Lorraine Motel.

3.

The 1920s, New York City. Jazz had just exploded across America.

Every night, jazz musicians _____ (play) in clubs from Harlem all the way downtown.

4.

October 1929. Just days before the crash, investors felt confident.

When Wall Street collapsed, many people still _____ (celebrate) the economic boom.

5.

September 11, 2001. A normal Tuesday morning — until it wasn't.

What _____ you _____ (do) when you first heard the news?

6.

August 28, 1963. Half a million people had come to Washington D.C.

When King delivered his famous speech, the crowd _____ (listen) in complete silence.

7.

November 4, 2008. The results were coming in live on TV.

When Obama was announced as the winner, millions of Americans _____ (watch) from their living rooms.

8.

December 7, 1941. A quiet Sunday morning at a US naval base in Hawaii.

When the Japanese planes arrived, sailors at Pearl Harbor _____ (sleep) and _____ (eat) breakfast.

Exercise 4 — Mixed: Used To or Past Continuous?

Read each sentence. Decide: a habit/state from the past (**used to**) or an action in progress at one specific moment (**past continuous**)? Rewrite the part in **[BRACKETS]**.

1.

Before 1776, Britain controlled the American colonies.

America **[HAVE 13 colonies]**, all of them under British rule.

2.

July 4, 1776. Philadelphia. The final vote had just been taken.

While the founders signed the Declaration, Thomas Jefferson **[WATCH]** proudly from his seat.

3.

Before the Civil War, the southern economy depended on enslaved labour.

Millions of people **[LIVE and WORK as enslaved people]** in the South before abolition in 1865.

4.

July 20, 1969. Every TV set on earth was switched on.

The whole world **[WATCH]** as Apollo 11 touched down on the moon.

5.

Before the railroads, cattle drives could take months.

Cowboys **[DRIVE huge herds across the West]** — it was the only way to get cattle to market.

6.

August 1945. American forces expected a long war in the Pacific.

When news of the atomic bomb arrived, American soldiers **[PREPARE for a land invasion of Japan]**.

7.

Before TV, families gathered around the radio every evening.

Americans **[LISTEN to the radio together every evening]** before television changed everything.

8.

November 22, 1963. Dallas. The motorcade was moving through the city.

When JFK was shot, the crowd along the street **[WAVE and CHEER]** — nobody knew what was about to happen.

9.

Before the internet, journalists worked very differently.

Reporters **[TYPE stories on paper and send them by fax]** — email and online news didn't exist yet.

10.

November 4, 2008. Chicago. A huge crowd had gathered in Grant Park.

When Obama gave his victory speech, thousands of supporters **[CRY with joy]** in the crowd.